

The 7 Cs of Communication

Whether at work or during our personal lives, good communication skills are essential. They can improve relationships, further your career, and build your social confidence.

The 7 Cs can be applied to all forms of communication, whether that's writing an email, creating marketing content, giving a presentation, having a job interview, or chairing a meeting. You can use the 7 Cs of communication checklist to ensure you're a more productive and effective communicator:



Clear

Clarity is ensuring what you're saying is communicated clearly and with no room for misunderstanding. Good advice for being clear includes:

- Use simple language and focus on core points of your message
- Don't use idioms to prevent any confusion and ambiguity

- Be clear in your mind about what you want to say and its purpose before you say it

Concise

Convey your points in a succinct and concise way. Short sentences are more likely to keep the attention of the listener, so try to use as little words as possible to communicate your message.

Concise communication is non-repetitive, saves time, and is more comprehensible for the audience.

Concrete

A concrete message is precise and backed by confidence as well as the use of supporting facts and figures.

Correct

You should use the most suitable language for your specific message, and the best form of communication. Correctness also means keeping your language free of mistakes, whether that's grammatical, spelling, or other inaccuracies.

Coherent

Coherent conversation makes sense and flows logically. Think carefully about the order of your points and how you can make it come across in an easy-to-understand way. It's also important to be consistent with style and content when delivering multiple forms of communications.

Complete

Make sure nothing is missing. Complete communication ensures the audience has all the information they need, and are able to easily come to the desired conclusion. Good ways to be complete include:

- Providing a 'call to action' i.e. what you would like your audience to do after receiving the message?
- Including hyperlinks in written content to ensure all information is provided

Courteous

It's important to be polite and respectful of your audience. Being friendly, considerate, and professional will make your communications much more effective. You should also be transparent, open, and honest, and be happy to answer any questions if applicable.

Body Language

Our body keeps sending some signals even when we are silent. These signals may be a smile or a frown, a slouched or an alert posture, sleepy or sparkling eyes, folded or open arms, etc., and they certainly communicate some messages to the onlookers.

When we meet people for the first time, we quickly make judgments about their behaviour, irrespective of the fact that our judgment may or may not be correct. We do this because actions speak louder than words. Anything visual attracts us and enters our minds quicker than anything verbal; actions speak louder than words. In fact, we tend to believe the body language signals more than the spoken words.

Communication through science symbols and body language, or any other visuals, is known as non-verbal communication. It uses all means other than the spoken or written words. Though it generally accompanies or substantiates your spoken or written words, it can also stand alone. For example, when you see a road sign or signal, you get some message. Similarly, when you see a smile or frown on people's face, you get a cue on there, like a dislike. However, not everyone is good at using body language appropriately. Some may like your idea, but they may not smile or not. Contrary wise, some may fake their expressions, even if they do not agree with you. Hence, it is not advisable to decide on anything purely based on non-verbal communication. At the same time, it can't be ignored. Of course, with experience, we will be able to interpret the non-verbal signals correctly. The branch of learning that deals with body language is known as kind kinesics.

Features of Body Language

Our body communicates through various features such as facial expressions, gestures, postures, eye contact, space, appearance and touch. Let us look at them briefly:

Facial Expressions

Your face is capable of displaying positive emotions such as passion, enthusiasm, happiness, cheerfulness, etc., and negative emotions, namely, melancholy, gloom, boredom, anger, frustration, disgust, hatred, etc., thereby communicating your intentions to others as you. As your face is the index of your mind, you may find it difficult to fake your expressions. However, some people are good at inhibiting their real expressions. Of course, exercising some control over your facial expressions may be required at times. For instance, when your boss reprimands you, you may be very angry with him, but it would not be advisable to express your anger explicitly; However, natural expressions always reflect your inner mind; when you appreciate someone, besides using complimentary words and handshake; you should also wear a nice mild on your face.

Postures

The way you set, standard move mirrors your attitude and intentions, your confidence or diffidence, your alertness or apathy, your humility or arrogance, your submissiveness or dominance can be communicated through your postures. When you are delivering a presentation, you can stand straight with your head held high and with your eyes looking at your audience, not only to show, but also to feel that you are confident. Similarly, when you are sitting in front of an interview panel, you can sit in a slightly leaning forward posture to reflect your alacrity.

Gestures

Gestures are observed actions. They involve the movements of hands, legs and other parts of your body to express something. In fact, expressive gestures enable you to convey your feelings, thoughts and sentiments. For instance, when people disturb you, when you are thinking about something, you can just put your finger on your lips to ask them to keep quiet. Likewise, when few students disturb the class, the professor may just stretch his hands and point towards the door to convey that the students should leave the class.

The five types of gestures which are commonly used are enumerative, locative, descriptive, symbolic and emphatic gestures. Enumerative gestures involve the display of numerals (1,2,3, etc) through fingers while locative gestures use the fingers or hands to show the location of something. For instance, when you wish to show the direction of some place, you show your hand right, left or straight. Descriptive gestures are those body signs used to describe the size or structure of an object, person, place, etc, or a situation (e.g. when you wish to say that someone is very tall, you raise your hand above your head). Symbolic gestures require you to use appropriate symbols to express abstract concepts such as cooperation, peace, unity, etc, and finally, emphatic gestures or signs used to emphasize any idea. They are also known as beat gestures, which are small taps or rhythmic emphasis used to drive home a point. For instance, you may tap your table to emphasize your argument.

Remember that the gestures should support your words because well - timed and well - made gestures are very effective. On the other hand, you should avoid certain distracting gestures, such as scratching your face, playing with the key rings, etc., during your conversations or presentations, as such gestures do not go with your words, but may signify your apathy.

Eye Contact

Having an eye contact during a communication process is an important sign of your confidence, interest, truthfulness, respect, involvement and gregariousness. You might have noticed that when people lie, they invariably avoid eye contact.

Eye contact enables the communicators to

- Gauge their interest/ enthusiasm/ passion on the topic
- Modify strategies if necessary
- Build a rapport among them
- Make their communication lively and dynamic
- Display their care for each other in understanding the message

However, you should remember the following:

- Do not stare at others while communicating.
- If you are delivering a presentation, do not ignore any particular section; keep shifting your gaze.
- Do not look outside or at the floor/ roof while speaking to a person/ group.
- If you are communicating to a large number of people in a huge hall, look at one or two people somewhere sitting in the middle in each section; this will give an impression that you are looking at the group.
- In a small group communication, do not look at only one or two because the others may feel that they are ignored.

Eye contact should come naturally and should always be purposeful. As a speaker, you wish to make eye contact to know whether your listeners are interested and have understood your message. And as

a receiver, you wish to know if the speakers are interested and enthusiastic, and also to tell them that you have gotten their message.

Personal Appearance

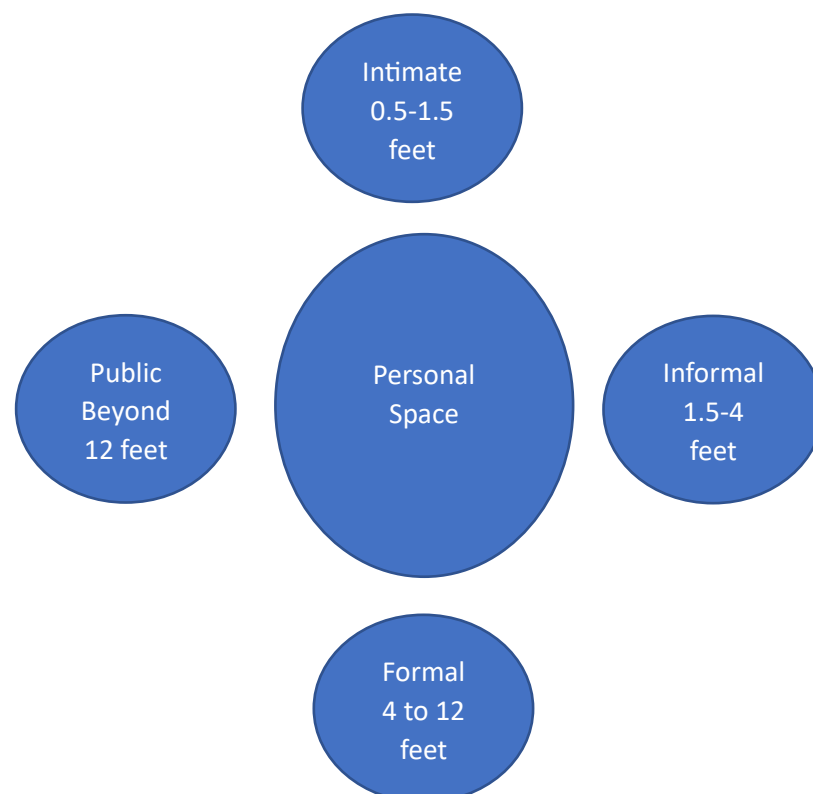
Personal appearance is often a disregarded part of communication skill. However, you need to realize that most people are habituated to form an impression about the speakers as soon as they appear on stage or in front of them. Hence, it is important to take care of your grooming attire and accessories while getting ready to participate in any form of oral communication.

Similarly, when you appear for an interview, you are expected to be dressed in formal attire not only to create the first impression among the interview panel members, but also to show them that you are serious about your job and interview.

So, spend a few minutes to check your personal appearance - your hair is well combed, you smell good, your dress suits the occasion and your accessories match your attire. Though you should choose your clothing appropriate to various situations, you should also feel comfortable in your clothing and accessories.

Personal Space

Personal space can be defined as the physical space immediately surrounding a person. The space can be classified into four zones intimate, informal, formal/ social and public.



Intimate Zone, a diameter of about 0.5 to 1.5 feet, refers to the distance we keep with emotionally attached people close to us like parents, siblings, spouse, etc. Here, the concept of space is almost ignored because the communicating parties understand each other very well.

Informal zone, a diameter of about 1.5 inches to four feet. Refers to the space that we keep with others during social gatherings, official parties, etc. and also when our friends visit us.

Formal zone is of about 4 to 12 feet diameter. We keep formal distance at our workplaces while communicating with not so familiar colleagues at our home when a plumber or carpenter comes for setting right some equipment. In short, this zone is used during our communication with strangers.

Public zone a space of more than 12 feet is observed during mass communication or while addressing a large number of people. For instance, the national leaders stand in this zone during an election rally, or any other public meetings.

Touch

Shaking hands, touching someone's feet, patting someone's back, slapping someone - all these touches do communicate your intentions or feelings. You shake hands to greet, touch someone's feet to show respect, pat someone's back to appreciate and slap someone to communicate your anger. Touch is mostly used as a means of communication in informal situations, though handshakes are commonly used in all formal situations.